

05__invested__fairplay-ai.json

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{
  "company_name": "FairPlay AI",
  "founded_year": 2020,
  "headquarters": "Los Angeles, CA",
  "founders": [
    {
      "name": "Kareem Saleh",
      "role": "Founder & CEO",
      "background": "Former executive at Zest.ai and SoftCard; served in the Obama Administration managing international investment teams."
    },
    {
      "name": "John Merrill",
      "role": "Co-founder & Principal Scientist",
      "background": "Mathematician and AI expert; previously a lead scientist at Zest.ai and spent 15 years at Microsoft and Google building ML tools."
    }
  ],
  "founding_team": {
    "key_personnel": [
      {
        "name": "Patrick Cadic",
        "role": "COO",
        "background": "Experienced operations leader in fintech and high-growth startups."
      },
      {
        "name": "Abby Hogan",
        "role": "SVP of Legal Affairs",
        "background": "Specialist in regulatory compliance and fair lending law."
      },
      {
        "name": "Mark Eberstein",
        "role": "EVP of Data Science",
        "background": "Expert in algorithmic fairness and statistical modeling."
      }
    ]
  },
  "team_composition": "The team includes veterans from Microsoft, Google, PayPal, and Goldman Sachs, specializing in AI safety, regulatory law, and consumer finance."
},
  "traction": {
    "funding": {
      "total_funding": "$24.5 Million",
      "latest_round": "$10 Million (February 2025)",
      "lead_investors": "Infinity Ventures",
      "participating_investors": [
        "JPMorganChase",
        "Nyca Partners",
        "Cross River Digital Ventures",
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    "TTV Capital",
    "Third Prime Capital"
  ],
},
"milestones": [
  "Reported a 3x increase in revenue and client base throughout 2024.",
  "Established multi-year partnerships with major financial institutions including Chime, Upgrade, Pathward, and Varo Bank.",
  "Integrated with risk platforms like Oscilar to provide embedded fairness tools to their customer networks.",
  "Currently serves over 25 banks and fintechs, managing fairness for billions in loan volume."
],
},
"problem_statement": {
  "core_issue": "The 'Black Box' Bias Problem: As banks move to AI-driven underwriting, they risk inheriting historical biases that lead to unfair rejection of protected classes.",
  "barriers": [
    "Regulatory Pressure: Agencies like the CFPB and regulators under SR 11-7 require AI models to be transparent, explainable, and fair.",
    "Manual Inefficiency: Traditional fair-lending audits take months and are based on 'batch' data rather than real-time monitoring.",
    "The 'Second Look' Gap: Lenders often lack an automated way to re-evaluate 'near-miss' applicants who are creditworthy but flagged by biased algorithms."
  ],
},
"solution": {
  "primary_product": "Fairness-as-a-Service™ Platform",
  "key_features": [
    "Automated Bias Testing: APIs that back-test and monitor models in real-time to identify disparate impacts on protected groups.",
    "Second-Look Underwriting: An automated system that re-underwrites declined applications to find creditworthy borrowers the primary model missed.",
    "SR 11-7 Compliance: Auto-generates regulatory-ready documentation, cutting validation cycles from months to days.",
    "Agentic AI Validation: Independent evaluation tools for AI agents to ensure they remain safe and compliant in financial environments.",
    "Fairness Optimization: Proprietary 'loss functions' that teach models to maximize approvals while minimizing disparity during the training phase."
  ],
  "value_proposition": "Enabling financial institutions to increase approval rates (typically 10-20%) and revenue without increasing risk, all while maintaining perfect regulatory compliance."
}
}

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